

THE FISH

Pisces



SIZE RANKING 14

BRIGHTEST STAR
Eta (η) 3.6

GENITIVE
Piscium

ABBREVIATION Psc

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
October–November

FULLY VISIBLE
83°N–56°S



This zodiacal constellation represents two mythical fish (see panel, right). Its main claim to fame is that it contains the vernal equinox, which is the point where the Sun crosses the celestial equator into the Northern Hemisphere each year in March—on star maps, this is where 0h right ascension intersects 0° declination. Because of the slow wobble of the Earth, known as precession (see p.64), the point of the vernal equinox is gradually moving along the celestial equator and will enter Aquarius in about 2600 CE.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

The most distinctive feature of Pisces is the ring of seven stars lying south of the Great Square of Pegasus. Known as the Circlet, this ring marks the body of one of the fish. It includes TX Piscium (also known as 19 Piscium), a deep-orange-colored red giant that fluctuates irregularly between magnitudes 4.8 and 5.2.

Alrescha (α) is a close pair of stars of 4th and 5th magnitudes that can be separated with a telescope with an aperture of 4 in (100 mm). These two stars form a true binary with an orbital period of more than 3,000 years. Zeta (ζ) and Psi-1 (ψ¹) Piscium are two more doubles that can be divided with a small telescope.

A beautiful face-on spiral galaxy, M74, lies just over two diameters of a full moon from the constellation's brightest star, Eta (η) Piscium. It appears as a round, bright glow through a small telescope; the spiral arms only show up well through a telescope with larger aperture and on long-exposure photographs.



THE CIRCLET

The body of the southerly fish is marked by a ring of stars called the Circlet. One of the stars, TX Piscium, is a red giant of variable brightness, which appears noticeably orange through binoculars.

DIVERGENCE

Pisces represents a pair of fish tied together by their tails with ribbon. The point where the two ribbons are knotted together is marked by the star Alpha (α) Piscium.

MYTHS AND STORIES

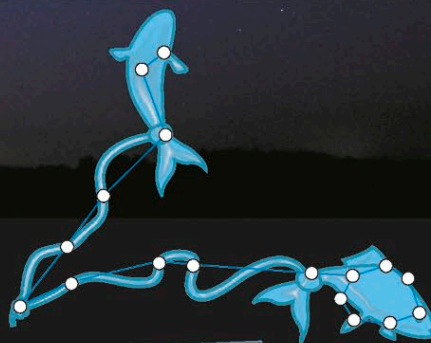
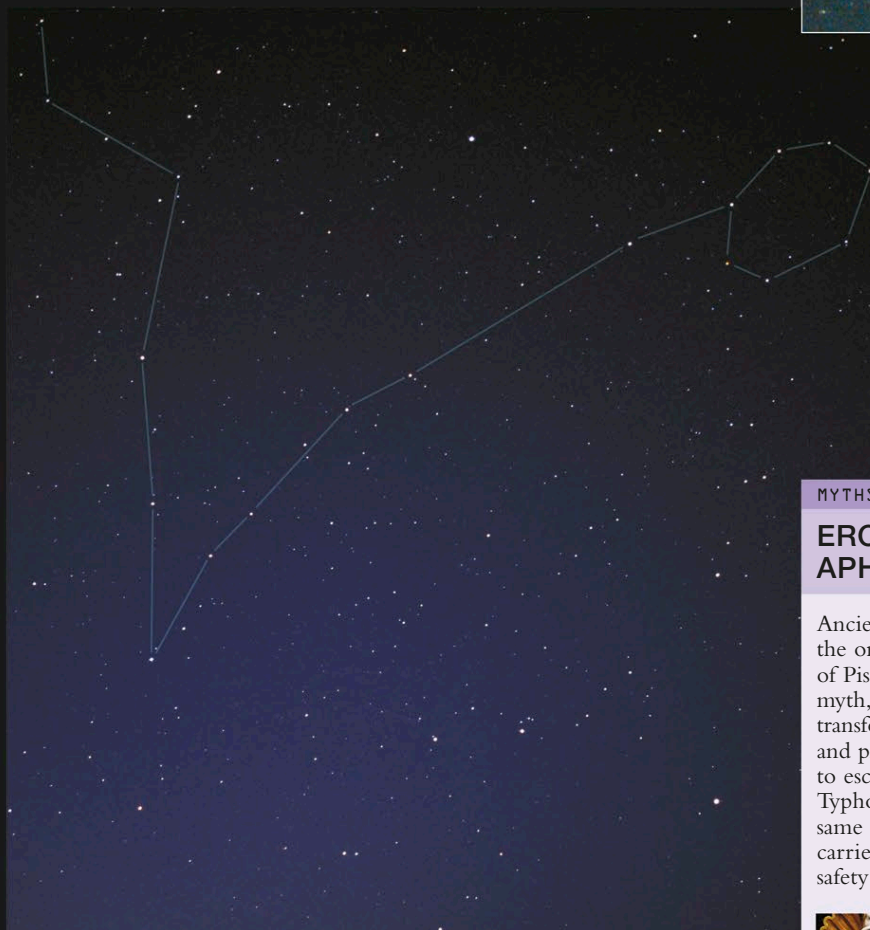
EROS AND APHRODITE

Ancient Greek myths concerning the origins of the constellation of Pisces are rather vague. In one myth, Aphrodite and her son Eros transformed themselves into fish and plunged into the Euphrates to escape the fearsome monster Typhon. In another version of the same story, two fish swam up and carried Aphrodite and Eros to safety on their backs.



RESCUE AT SEA

In this 17th-century painting by the Flemish artist Jacob Jordaens, Aphrodite and Eros are carried away on the back of a fish.



THE FISH

M74

The spiral galaxy M74 is seen face-on and appears as a rounded glow when viewed through a small telescope. Larger apertures are needed to see its spiral arms.

